

2.1 Changing Places

1. The Nature and Importance of Places

Place: A location that has been given meaning by people through lived experience, memory, and attachment. Places are more than physical locations — they carry social, cultural, economic, and emotional significance. Place is a central concept in human geography, connecting identity, belonging, and experience to specific locations. As geographer Yi-Fu Tuan argued, a place is a "centre of meaning" constructed by experience.

Space vs Place: *Space* is an abstract, undefined area with no particular human meaning — a geometric concept. *Place* is a space that has been given meaning through human experience, memory, naming, and attachment. A coordinate on a map is a space; your home, your school, your neighbourhood are places. The transformation from space to place occurs through human engagement.

Key Concepts of Place

- **Location** — the geographical position of a place. *Absolute location*: precise coordinates (latitude/longitude). *Relative location*: position in relation to other places, transport links, or features (e.g. "20 minutes from Manchester city centre").
- **Locale** — the physical setting in which social relations and interactions occur. It includes the built environment, layout, and tangible characteristics of a place (e.g. a marketplace, a park, a factory floor, a high street). The locale shapes how people use and experience the place.
- **Sense of place** — the subjective, emotional attachment people feel towards a place. This is deeply personal and varies between individuals. It develops through repeated experience, memories, relationships, and cultural associations.
- **Perception of place** — how an individual or group views and interprets a place, shaped by direct experience, media representations, education, cultural background, and identity. Perception may or

may not match reality.

- **Spirit of place (genius loci)** — the unique atmosphere or character that distinguishes one place from another. This is what makes Paris feel different from New York, or a rural village different from a housing estate.

Insider and Outsider Perspectives

Perspective	Description	Characteristics	Example
Insider	Someone who lives in or has deep personal experience of a place	Subjective, emotional, detailed knowledge, sense of belonging, shaped by everyday experience, may take features for granted	A lifelong resident of a mining village who remembers the pit, the community spirit, the decline
Outsider	Someone who observes a place without personal connection or prolonged experience	More detached, potentially superficial, shaped by media/stereotypes, may lack nuance but can notice things insiders overlook	A tourist visiting the same village, seeing picturesque scenery and heritage but not understanding the economic hardship

Relph (1976) described a spectrum from **existential insideness** (deep, unselfconscious belonging — "this is where I truly belong") to **existential outsideness** (feeling alienated, estranged, and disconnected from a place). Most people's experience falls somewhere between these extremes.

Exam Tip: AQA expects you to understand that place meaning is *contested* — different groups (long-term residents, newcomers, developers, tourists, local government, ethnic minorities) may have very different views of the same place. Always consider multiple perspectives in your answers and explain *why* perspectives differ.

2. Factors Shaping Place Character

The character of a place is shaped by a combination of endogenous (internal) and exogenous (external) factors that interact and change over time:

Endogenous (Internal) Factors

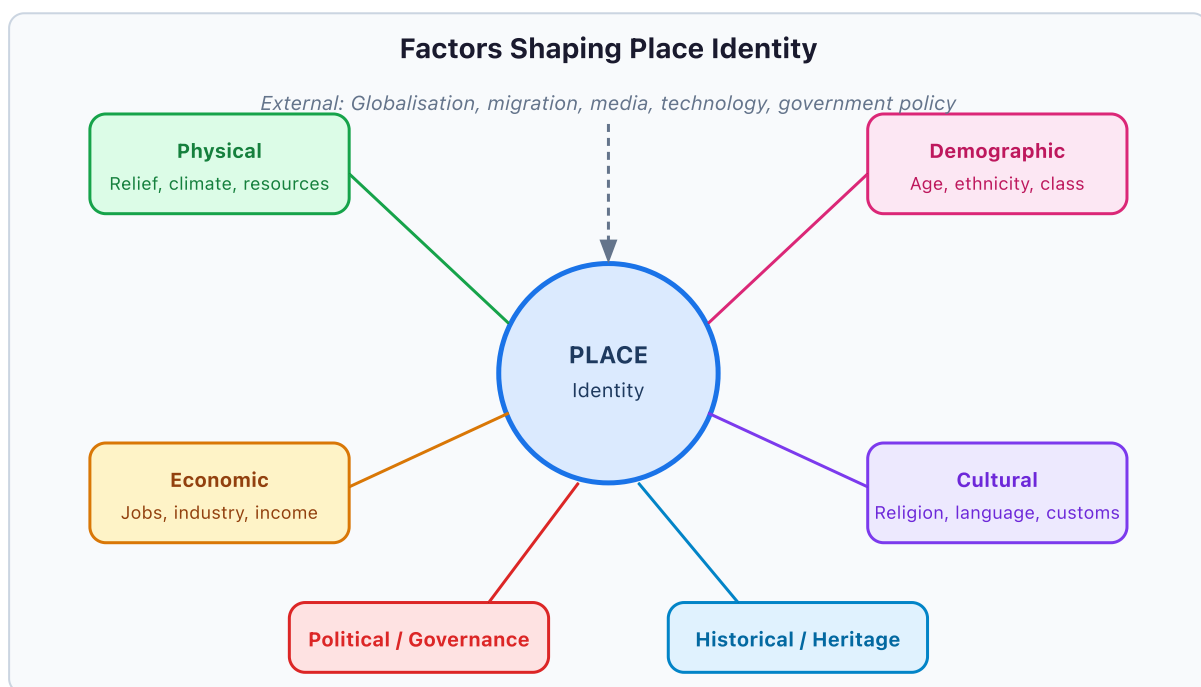
- **Physical geography** — relief, drainage, climate, soil, natural resources, natural hazard exposure. Physical characteristics fundamentally shape what a place can be: a coastal settlement differs from an inland valley town.
- **Location and accessibility** — proximity to transport routes (motorways, railways, airports, ports), distance from other settlements, connectivity to markets and services.
- **Built environment** — architecture, land use, infrastructure, heritage buildings, street layout, urban design. Buildings embody the economic and cultural history of a place (e.g. Victorian terraces reflect industrialisation, glass towers reflect globalised finance).
- **Demographic characteristics** — age structure, ethnicity, socioeconomic composition, education levels, population density. These determine the social character of a place.
- **Cultural factors** — religion, language, customs, traditions, community organisations, local identity and pride, artistic and musical heritage.
- **Economic characteristics** — employment types (primary/secondary/tertiary/quaternary), income levels, economic history, dominant industries, levels of deprivation.
- **Historical factors** — past events and processes that have left a mark: industrialisation, deindustrialisation, wartime bombing, migration waves, past planning decisions, heritage designations.

Exogenous (External) Factors

Places are also shaped by forces operating beyond the local scale:

- **Globalisation** — global flows of capital, people, ideas, and culture can transform local places. TNCs opening or closing factories, chain stores replacing independents, cultural homogenisation, foreign direct investment decisions made in distant boardrooms.
- **International and national migration** — in-migration and out-migration alter demographic, cultural, and economic character. Post-war migration transformed areas like Brick Lane (London), Sparkbrook (Birmingham), and Moss Side (Manchester).
- **Government policy** — national and local policies on housing, transport, planning, regeneration, enterprise zones, devolution, and austerity shape places profoundly. E.g. New Town designations (Milton Keynes, 1967), Enterprise Zones, Housing Market Renewal.

- **Technology** — digital connectivity, remote working, and social media reshape how places function and are perceived. The rise of e-commerce has devastated high streets while boosting warehouse districts.
- **Shifting flows of investment** — decisions by investors, corporations, and governments to invest in or withdraw from specific places can transform them rapidly. Capital is highly mobile in a globalised world.
- **Media representation** — how places are portrayed in news, film, TV, literature, and social media profoundly influences external perception and can attract or deter investment, tourism, and migration.



3. Representation of Place

Place representation: How a place is portrayed, depicted, or "constructed" by different agents (media, government, artists, residents, businesses). Representations can reinforce, challenge, or create specific images of a place. They are always selective — choosing what to include and exclude — and they carry the perspective, purpose, and bias of their creator. Representations shape perceptions and influence real-world decisions about investment, migration, tourism, and policy.

Formal (Official/Quantitative) Representations

- **Maps and GIS data** — seemingly objective but choices about scale, projection, colour, and what to include carry implicit bias.
- **Census data and government statistics** — ONS data on population, employment, health, education, crime. The Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD) ranks every neighbourhood in England across 7 domains.
- **Planning documents** — local development plans, regeneration strategies, housing strategies present an official vision of what a place should become.
- **Tourism marketing** — councils and agencies create selective, positive images to attract visitors and investment. They emphasise heritage, scenery, and culture while omitting deprivation and social problems.
- **Academic studies** — geographical surveys, demographic analyses, environmental assessments.

Informal (Unofficial/Qualitative) Representations

- **Film and television** — fictional representations shape place image powerfully and enduringly. "Downton Abbey" romanticised the English countryside, "Peaky Blinders" rebranded Birmingham's industrial past, "The Full Monty" captured Sheffield's post-industrial decline.
- **Literature and poetry** — writers create powerful sense of place through descriptive language. Dickens' London, Hardy's Wessex, Brontë's Yorkshire moors.
- **Photography and art** — subjective visual representations that emphasise particular aspects. L.S. Lowry's paintings defined the industrial north in popular imagination.
- **Music** — lyrics and cultural associations link places to genres and emotions. Manchester and indie/Britpop (Oasis, The Smiths), Liverpool and The Beatles, Nashville and country music.
- **Social media** — user-generated content, Instagram images, TripAdvisor reviews, Twitter hashtags, and viral posts create real-time collective perceptions that can boost or damage a place's reputation.
- **Oral histories and personal accounts** — individual stories reveal the lived experience of a place, capturing perspectives that statistics miss.
- **Newspaper reporting** — can stigmatise or celebrate places through selective coverage. Negative reporting about crime or deprivation can become self-fulfilling.

Exam Tip: When analysing a representation of place in the exam (e.g. a photograph, map extract, text, or advertisement), always consider: (1) Who created it? (2) Why? What is its purpose? (3)

What is included/emphasised? (4) What is excluded/downplayed? (5) What impression does it give? (6) How might different groups interpret it? (7) Is it biased? Every representation is selective — identify the selection.

4. Approaches to Studying Place

Quantitative Data

Numerical data that can be measured, counted, and analysed statistically:

- Census data (population size, age, ethnicity, employment, housing tenure, qualifications)
- Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD) — composite measure across income, employment, education, health, crime, housing, and living environment. Published for every Lower Super Output Area (LSOA) in England.
- Land use surveys, traffic counts, pedestrian flow counts, environmental quality index (EQI) scores
- House price data (Land Registry), unemployment rates (ONS), crime statistics (police.uk)
- GIS mapping, satellite imagery, OS maps

Qualitative Data

Non-numerical data that captures meaning, perception, experience, and emotion:

- Semi-structured interviews and oral histories with residents, workers, and visitors
- Photographs and visual surveys (photo elicitation: asking participants to photograph what matters to them)
- Analysis of text (newspaper articles, literature, social media posts, council documents)
- Field sketches, annotated photographs, soundscapes (recording the audio environment of a place)
- Mental maps — asking people to draw their perception of an area reveals what matters to them, what they know, and what they avoid
- Participant observation and ethnographic research (immersing oneself in a community)

Mental map: A person's internal, subjective representation of an area, shaped by their experiences, perceptions, and values. Mental maps reveal what places and features are important

to an individual, where they feel safe or unsafe, and can expose social and spatial inequalities. They are inherently incomplete and biased — that is their value.

5. Place Identity, Attachment, and Belonging

Factors Influencing Sense of Place

- **Age** — older residents may have deeper emotional attachments built over decades of lived experience; young people may identify more with virtual spaces or aspire to leave for opportunities elsewhere.
- **Gender** — men and women may experience the same place differently (e.g. women's safety perceptions in public spaces, access to services, use of transport).
- **Sexuality** — LGBTQ+ communities may feel welcome and visible in some places (e.g. Brighton, Manchester's Gay Village, Soho) and marginalised or unsafe in others.
- **Ethnicity and religion** — cultural identity strongly shapes sense of belonging and place attachment. Ethnic enclaves (e.g. Brick Lane/Banglatown, Chinatown, Little Italy) can provide belonging, community support, and cultural continuity, but may also indicate limited integration or structural inequality.
- **Socioeconomic status** — wealthier residents may perceive a place more positively and have more power to shape it; deprivation can create negative perceptions, stigma, and desire to leave.
- **Length of residence** — long-term residents develop deeper roots and stronger attachment; newcomers may feel like outsiders, especially if the community is resistant to change.
- **Personal experience** — positive memories (childhood, friendships, achievements) strengthen attachment; negative experiences (crime, discrimination, loss) can weaken it.

Placelessness and Globalisation

Placelessness: The loss of unique place identity, leading to standardised, homogeneous landscapes that could be "anywhere". Associated with globalisation, chain stores (clone towns), out-of-town retail parks, motorway service stations, identical suburban housing estates, and international hotel chains. Geographer Edward Relph (1976) argued that mass culture, mass

tourism, and corporate standardisation strip places of their authentic character, creating "an environment without significant places."

The New Economics Foundation (NEF) coined the term "**clone town**" in 2004, finding that many UK high streets had become dominated by identical chain stores, making one town indistinguishable from another. Their research found that for every £1 spent in a local independent shop, 50–70p recirculated locally, compared to only 5–15p from chain stores.

Key Theoretical Perspectives on Place

Theorist/Concept	Key Ideas	Relevance
Yi-Fu Tuan (1974) — <i>Topophilia</i>	Topophilia means "love of place" — the affective bond between people and place. Our experience of place is shaped by perception, attitude, and values. Places become meaningful through lived experience, not just observation. We experience place through all our senses.	Explains why people develop deep emotional connections to places and resist change. Useful for understanding NIMBY responses and community opposition to development.
Edward Relph (1976) — <i>Place and Placelessness</i>	Authentic sense of place comes from deep insider knowledge and unselfconscious immersion. Mass culture, mass media, and globalisation create "placelessness" — inauthentic, interchangeable environments. Distinguished between levels of insideness and outsideness.	Explains the impact of globalisation on local identity. Useful for evaluating clone towns, retail parks, and standardised urban development. Critique: romanticises a "pure" past that may never have existed.

Doreen Massey (1991) — <i>A Global Sense of Place</i>	Places are not static, bounded, or defined by a single identity. They are shaped by external connections, flows of people, capital, and ideas. A "progressive" sense of place embraces diversity, hybridity, and change rather than nostalgic, exclusionary, defensive identities. Places are "meeting points" of wider social relations.	Challenges exclusionary place identities (e.g. "this is OUR place"). Useful for discussing multiculturalism, gentrification, and globalisation. The most contemporary and inclusive perspective.
David Harvey (1989) — <i>Time-space compression</i>	Advances in transport and communication have "shrunk" the world, changing how we experience distance and place. This process benefits some (the mobile, wealthy, connected) while marginalising others (the immobile, poor, disconnected). The experience of time-space compression is deeply unequal.	Explains why globalisation transforms some places but bypasses others. Useful for discussing digital divides, transport connectivity, and uneven development.
Pierre Bourdieu — <i>Cultural capital</i>	People's knowledge, tastes, education, and social connections (cultural capital) shape how they experience and benefit from places. Those with more cultural capital are better able to navigate, enjoy, and profit from particular places.	Explains why gentrification benefits newcomers (high cultural capital) while displacing existing residents. Useful for discussing inequality within places.

6. How and Why Places Change

Processes of Change

- Deindustrialisation** — the decline of manufacturing industry, particularly in traditional industrial areas. In the UK, manufacturing employment fell from 7.9 million (1971) to 2.7 million (2020). Caused by globalisation (cheaper production overseas), automation, competition, and the shift to a service economy. Created widespread unemployment, deprivation, and loss of community identity in places like Sheffield, Glasgow, Teesside, and the Welsh Valleys.

- **Globalisation** — integration into global economic networks can bring investment and jobs (e.g. Sunderland attracting Nissan in 1986) or cause decline (e.g. textile industries relocating to Bangladesh and Vietnam).
- **Government policy** — planning decisions, regeneration programmes, infrastructure investment, austerity measures, housing policy, and devolution all reshape places. The New Town movement (1946–1970) created 32 new towns in the UK.
- **Gentrification** — the process by which wealthier people move into a previously deprived area, renovating housing and changing the social character. Property values rise, independent shops are replaced by boutiques and coffee shops, and existing low-income residents may be displaced by rising rents.
- **Regeneration** — planned investment to revitalise a declining area, improving infrastructure, housing, employment, and public spaces. Can be property-led, culture-led, community-led, or transport-led.
- **Migration** — both international and internal migration transform the demographic, cultural, and economic character of places.
- **Suburbanisation, counter-urbanisation, and reurbanisation** — shifts in where people choose to live reshape the character of both the places they leave and the places they move to.
- **Technological change** — the rise of e-commerce, remote working, and the gig economy are transforming town centres, office districts, and residential areas.

Case Study: Shoreditch, London — Gentrification and Creative Regeneration

Shoreditch in East London has undergone dramatic transformation since the 1990s. Once a deprived, post-industrial area with high unemployment and low property values, it attracted artists, designers, and tech start-ups seeking cheap studio space. By the 2000s, galleries, bars, restaurants, and creative industries had established a thriving "scene". Property values soared: average house prices in Hackney (the borough containing Shoreditch) rose from ~£100,000 (2000) to ~£550,000 (2023). Tech companies (including "Silicon Roundabout" firms) located there, attracted by the creative cachet. **Positive impacts:** economic revitalisation, cultural vibrancy, job creation, improved public realm, reduced crime. **Negative impacts:** displacement of low-income residents (social housing waiting lists grew), loss of affordable workspace for the artists who created the area's appeal, independent shops replaced by chains, homogenisation of a previously diverse area, rising homelessness alongside rising wealth. Shoreditch illustrates the paradox of gentrification: the qualities that make a place attractive to newcomers are often destroyed by their arrival.

Case Study: Detroit, USA — Deindustrialisation and Decline

Detroit was the centre of the American automobile industry, home to General Motors, Ford, and Chrysler. Population peaked at 1.85 million (1950). Deindustrialisation, automation, competition from Japanese manufacturers, and the 2008 financial crisis caused catastrophic decline. Population fell to 639,000 (2020) — a loss of 65%. In 2013, Detroit became the largest US city to file for bankruptcy (\$18 billion debt). **Impacts:** 78,000 abandoned buildings, 40% of streetlights non-functional, average home price of \$7,500 (some houses sold for \$1), crime rates among the highest in the US, life expectancy 6 years below national average. **Recovery attempts:** \$1.8 billion in investment since bankruptcy, downtown revival (Dan Gilbert relocated Quicken Loans HQ, bringing 17,000 jobs), emerging tech sector, urban agriculture (1,400 urban farms), but benefits concentrated in central Detroit while outer neighbourhoods remain in severe decline. Detroit demonstrates how the withdrawal of a dominant industry can devastate an entire city's identity, economy, and population.

Case Study: Stratford, East London — Olympic Regeneration

Stratford was one of London's most deprived areas before being selected as the site for the 2012 Olympic Games. The Lower Lea Valley was a post-industrial landscape of contaminated brownfield land, scrapyards, and fragmented communities. **Investment:** £9.3 billion total Olympic investment; the Olympic Park (now Queen Elizabeth Olympic Park) created 560 acres of parkland, wetlands, and sports venues. The Athletes' Village became East Village — 2,818 homes (1,379 affordable). Westfield Stratford City shopping centre (175,000 m²) opened in 2011 with 300+ shops and 10,000 jobs. Transport: the Javelin shuttle, improved DLR and Overground, and Crossrail (Elizabeth Line) connections. **Positive impacts:** 11,000 new homes planned, 10,000+ new jobs, improved parkland and ecology (300+ species in the wetlands), educational facilities (UCL East campus). **Negative impacts:** displacement of existing businesses and residents (450 businesses relocated, many did not survive), rising property prices (average Newham house price rose from £215,000 in 2012 to £420,000 in 2023), gentrification concerns, legacy promises of affordable housing partially unmet (only 37% of new homes were affordable, below the 50% target). The regeneration was largely top-down and property-led, with limited community input in early stages.

7. Place-Making and Place Management

Place-making: The deliberate process of shaping a place's identity, character, and public spaces to improve quality of life, attract investment, and create a sense of community. It can be top-down (led by government or developers) or bottom-up (led by local communities and grassroots organisations).

Approaches to Place-Making

- **Flagship/property-led development** — large-scale iconic projects to attract investment and change perceptions (e.g. the Shard, Tate Modern, Guggenheim Bilbao). Can catalyse wider regeneration but may not benefit local residents.
- **Culture-led regeneration** — using arts, heritage, festivals, and creative industries to transform places (e.g. Baltic Gateshead, Northern Quarter Manchester, Hull UK City of Culture 2017).
- **Community-led initiatives** — neighbourhood plans, community land trusts, co-operatives, social enterprises, community gardens, and local campaigns. More inclusive but often lack resources.
- **Heritage-led approaches** — preserving and celebrating historical buildings, landscapes, and traditions to maintain identity (e.g. listed buildings, conservation areas, World Heritage Sites).
- **Transport-led regeneration** — new transport links catalysing development (e.g. Crossrail/Elizabeth Line stimulating regeneration in East London, HS2 planned impacts on Birmingham).

Conflicts in Place-Making

Place-making is inherently contested. Key tensions include:

- **Preservation vs development** — protecting heritage character vs allowing modernisation and growth.
- **Local needs vs external investment** — community priorities may differ from developer interests.
- **Gentrification vs affordability** — improving an area may displace the communities it aims to help.
- **Authenticity vs commercialisation** — marketing a place's character may commodify and ultimately destroy it.
- **Whose place?** — different groups contest ownership and meaning. Long-term residents, newcomers, businesses, government, and tourists may all claim different visions for a place.

Exam Tip: In the AQA Changing Places exam, you will likely be asked to analyse an unseen resource (photograph, map, data extract, text) and explain what it reveals about a place. Practice

reading visual and textual sources critically: What does it tell us? What does it NOT tell us? Whose perspective is it? What further information would you need?

Exam Tip: For the 20-mark essay, you need to demonstrate knowledge of both your local place study and a contrasting distant place. Use specific named evidence: statistics (IMD scores, population data, house prices, employment figures), named locations, and named theorists (Tuan, Relph, Massey, Harvey). Structure: clear argument with a thesis statement, supporting paragraphs with evidence, counterarguments, and a judged conclusion.

Exam Tip: AQA values *synoptic thinking* in Changing Places. Link place change to other parts of the specification: globalisation (population topic), urbanisation (urban environments topic), climate change (water/carbon topic), migration (population topic). Show that places do not exist in isolation — they are shaped by wider processes.

8. Attachment Theory and Topophilia

Yi-Fu Tuan's Topophilia

Topophilia (Tuan, 1974): Literally "love of place" (from Greek *topos* = place, *philia* = love). Tuan described topophilia as "the affective bond between people and place or setting." The bond can be profound and life-defining (a childhood home, a homeland) or subtle and fleeting (a pleasant afternoon in a park). Topophilia is built through direct sensory experience — the smell of a place, its sounds, its textures, its light. Tuan argued that true place attachment can only come from prolonged, intimate engagement — places must be "dwelt in" to be fully known.

Tuan distinguished between **topophilia** (positive place attachment) and **topophobia** (fear or aversion to a place). A former industrial worker may feel topophilia towards a now-demolished factory because it was the site of community, purpose, and identity, even though its physical environment was harsh. A child who experienced bullying at school may feel topophobia towards that building even decades later. These responses are deeply personal and socially constructed.

Relph's Levels of Place Experience

Edward Relph (1976) described a spectrum of place experience:

Level	Description	Example
Existential insideness	The deepest level: unselfconscious, complete belonging. You ARE the place; it is part of your identity. You don't think about being "in" it — you simply are.	A lifelong resident of a Welsh mining village whose family has lived there for four generations; the village is not a place they visit, it is who they are.
Empathetic insideness	Deliberate effort to understand a place from within, to see it through the eyes of those who belong. The attentive visitor or researcher who truly listens.	A geographer conducting long-term ethnographic fieldwork in a community, gradually building genuine understanding.
Behavioural insideness	Familiarity with the physical layout and routines of a place without deep emotional attachment. You know your way around.	A commuter who uses the same streets daily but feels no particular bond to them.
Incidental outsideness	The place is a backdrop to other activities; you are present but not engaged with the place itself.	A delivery driver passing through a town.
Objective outsideness	Detached, scientific observation. The place is an object of study, not a lived experience.	A surveyor measuring building heights for a planning report.
Existential outsideness	Alienation from all places; feeling homeless even in familiar surroundings. A profound sense of not belonging anywhere.	Displaced persons, refugees, or those experiencing severe depression may feel estranged from all environments.

Doreen Massey's "A Global Sense of Place" (1991)

Massey challenged what she called "reactionary" place identity — the nostalgic, backward-looking, exclusionary sense of a place as bounded, pure, and "ours." She argued instead for a **progressive** sense of place that:

- Recognises that places are **meeting points of wider social relations**, not sealed containers

- Embraces the **diversity and hybridity** that comes from being a node in global networks
- Does not seek to define place through **exclusion** of "outsiders"
- Accepts that place identity is **always changing** — it was never static or pure
- Values **multiple simultaneous identities** within the same place

Massey illustrated this with Kilburn High Road in London: an apparently local street that is actually a junction of global flows — Irish pubs, Bangladeshi restaurants, African hairdressers, global brands, refugees and returnees. For Massey, this cosmopolitan mix IS the place, not a corruption of it.

Exam Tip: Tuan, Relph, and Massey represent three key theoretical stances. Tuan = emotional/phenomenological (place as feeling). Relph = experiential spectrum (insider vs outsider). Massey = political/progressive (place as open, contested, relational). Use all three in essays. The best answers show how these theorists agree and disagree: Tuan and Relph both value deep attachment but Massey warns against using attachment to exclude others.

9. Named Place Studies

Doha, Qatar — A Globalised Place

Case Study: Doha, Qatar — Globalisation and Rapid Place Change

Doha (population ~2.4 million, of whom ~85% are foreign nationals) is one of the world's most extreme examples of globalisation reshaping place identity. In 1950, Doha was a small pearl-fishing and trading settlement of ~15,000 people with a built environment of low-rise, courtyard-style mud-brick structures. The discovery and export of oil (from the 1940s) and liquefied natural gas (1990s) generated extraordinary wealth and transformed the city within two generations.

Physical transformation: The West Bay skyline, featuring glass skyscrapers (including the iconic Tornado Tower), was built almost entirely in the 2000s–2010s. The Pearl-Qatar artificial island (reclaimed from the sea) was modelled on Mediterranean towns (Porto Arabia) and branded for global luxury consumption. Msheireb Downtown Doha, a \$5.5 billion urban regeneration project, controversially demolished much of the historic city centre to build a "sustainable modern Arab city." Lusail City, a brand-new urban area for 200,000 residents, is entirely planned and constructed from scratch.

Globalised character: Doha hosted the 2022 FIFA World Cup, embedding itself in global consciousness. Hamad International Airport is one of the world's busiest hubs, with Qatar Airways linking 160+ destinations. The Pearl hosts global brands (Bentley, Louis Vuitton), global restaurant chains, and international schools. Qatar Foundation has established Education City, hosting satellite campuses of Cornell, Georgetown, Northwestern, and other US universities. Al Jazeera media network broadcasts globally from Doha.

Place identity tensions: The rapid transformation has created complex identity questions. The Qatari national minority (15% of residents) seek to preserve Arab-Islamic heritage (Souq Waqif was reconstructed to resemble a traditional market), while the majority migrant population (workers from India, Nepal, Bangladesh, Philippines) experience Doha very differently — housed in labour camps on the urban periphery, with limited access to the gleaming city centre. The kafala system (tying workers to sponsors) restricts mobility and creates a two-tier place experience. Critics argue that Doha represents "placelessness" (Relph) — a globalised, branded environment that could be anywhere — while defenders argue that Qatari cultural heritage and Islamic identity remain central to the city's character.

Representation: Doha is represented very differently: to international visitors, it is a modern, cosmopolitan hub of luxury and culture; to labour rights organisations, it is a site of exploitation; to Qatari nationals, it is a symbol of national ambition and pride; to migrant workers, it is both opportunity and hardship. These contested representations illustrate how a single place can carry profoundly different meanings.

Port Isaac, Cornwall — A Rural Place Under Pressure

Case Study: Port Isaac, Cornwall — Rural Identity, Tourism, and Media Representation

Port Isaac (population ~750 permanent residents) is a small fishing village on the north Cornish coast. Its character is shaped by its physical setting (dramatic cliffs, narrow "drang" alleyways, a working harbour), its economic history (pilchard fishing, now tourism and a small residual fishing fleet), and its cultural identity (tight-knit community, strong local dialect, the "Fisherman's Friends" sea shanty group which gained national fame).

Economic change: The decline of the Cornish fishing industry (EU quota restrictions, falling fish

stocks, rising costs) has shifted Port Isaac's economy almost entirely towards tourism. Second homes and holiday lets now account for over 40% of properties in some parts of North Cornwall, driving local house prices beyond the reach of local workers (average house price in North Cornwall ~£320,000 vs median local salary ~£26,000). Young people and essential workers are priced out, hollowing out the year-round community.

Media representation and the "Doc Martin" effect: Port Isaac was the filming location for the ITV drama *Doc Martin* (2004–2022), in which the village was fictionalised as "Portwenn." The series attracted hundreds of thousands of "set visitors" each year, transforming the village into a heritage tourism site and creating the "Doc Martin effect" — measurable increases in tourism numbers and house prices following episodes. This demonstrates how media representation directly shapes place identity and economic character. The fictional Portwenn overlays and partially displaces the "real" Port Isaac in public perception.

Insider vs outsider tensions: Long-term residents experience the "Doc Martin effect" ambivalently: tourism brings economic benefits (holiday letting income, café/shop revenues) but transforms the village into a "film set" and crowds out everyday life during summer (the single road through the village can gridlock; parking fields replace farmland). Outsiders (day trippers, set visitors) experience Port Isaac through the lens of the TV drama — a romanticised, picturesque version of rural England — while insiders navigate the more complex realities of seasonal employment, inadequate public services, and out-migration of the young.

The Fisherman's Friends: The sea shanty group — formed from Port Isaac residents — released a Top 10 album in 2010 and had a feature film made about them (2019). They represent an authentic, community-rooted cultural tradition that has gained global exposure, offering a contrast to the mediated "Doc Martin" representation. Yet even the Fisherman's Friends' story has been commodified and packaged for external consumption, raising questions about authenticity and commercialisation.

Contrasting UK Local Area Examples

Case Study: Jaywick, Essex — Deprivation and Contested Identity

Jaywick Sands (population ~4,500) near Clacton-on-Sea has ranked as the most deprived neighbourhood in England in multiple editions of the Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD). Originally

built in the 1930s as a holiday chalet settlement, it gradually became a year-round residential area as low-cost housing attracted people on low incomes and benefits. The streets are named after types of car (Austin, Bentley, Morris) because developers originally planned to separate plots by vehicle type.

Deprivation indicators: IMD score places it in the top 0.1% most deprived LSOAs in England; 61% of properties are not connected to the main sewerage system; repeated severe flooding (2013 North Sea surge: 250 homes evacuated); no railway station, limited bus services; high rates of unemployment, benefit dependency, and poor health outcomes.

Representation: Jaywick has been repeatedly featured in media reports and TV documentaries on poverty ("Britain's Most Deprived Area"), which residents argue is stigmatising and one-dimensional. The media representation focuses on deprivation, crime, and physical decay, while ignoring strong community bonds, local pride, and grassroots initiatives. The "Brooklands" estate within Jaywick won an award for the UK's most improved community (2019) through resident-led environmental improvements. The gap between external representation (poverty tourism, stigma) and internal experience (community belonging, resilience, local pride) illustrates key geographical concepts about how places are constructed and contested.

Case Study: Hebden Bridge, West Yorkshire — Counter-urbanisation and Cultural Regeneration

Hebden Bridge (population ~4,500) in the Calder Valley is a former mill town that reinvented itself from the 1970s onwards after textile industry collapse. Its dramatic Pennine setting (deep valley, stone-built terraces, surrounding moorland) attracted artists, writers, and people seeking an alternative lifestyle when property was cheap. It became known for its independent shops, arts scene, and LGBTQ+ community (the "lesbian capital of the UK" in media representations), drawing counter-cultural migrants from cities.

Place change dynamics: Hebden Bridge illustrates how a post-industrial place can be transformed by cultural migration. The town now has cafés, bookshops, craft galleries, alternative health practices, and a thriving arts festival calendar. House prices have risen sharply (from well below average to above the West Yorkshire average) as its desirability increased. However, this has created affordability pressures similar to gentrification, potentially pricing out the very people who created its alternative character. Severe flooding (2015 Boxing Day floods; 2020) has complicated

its identity as a desirable rural retreat, highlighting climate vulnerability.

Sense of place: Hebden Bridge has a very strong insider community identity built around shared values (environmentalism, LGBTQ+ inclusion, arts, local independence) rather than historical ties. This demonstrates Massey's "progressive sense of place" — a diverse, open, values-based community that is not defined by exclusion. Yet the town also has tensions: long-term working-class residents who pre-date the cultural migration may feel the place's original identity has been displaced.

10. Research Methods for Place Study

Ethnographic Research

Ethnography: A research method in which the researcher immerses themselves in a community or place over an extended period to understand it from within. Originating in social anthropology, ethnography involves participant observation, informal conversations, and detailed field notes. It produces rich, contextual, qualitative data that reveals the lived experience of a place — how it feels, what rhythms and routines structure daily life, how different groups interact, what is contested and what is taken for granted.

For geographic place study, ethnographic approaches might include:

- **Extended fieldwork** — returning to a place multiple times over weeks or months, observing how it changes across the day, week, and season.
- **Walking interviews** — interviewing people as they walk through a place, which allows them to respond to immediate sensory cues and show what matters to them spatially.
- **Oral history recording** — systematic recording of long-term residents' memories of how a place has changed over time, capturing knowledge not available in official records.
- **Participant observation** — attending community events, local meetings, and everyday gatherings to observe social dynamics and community identity in action.

Strengths: produces deeply contextual, authentic insights that surveys cannot capture; reveals hidden perspectives; allows unexpected findings to emerge; the researcher gains genuine understanding from the inside. **Limitations:** time-intensive; small scale (cannot be generalised); researcher bias and

subjectivity (the researcher's own identity affects what they observe and how); ethical challenges (obtaining informed consent in public spaces; risk of "going native" and losing analytical distance); findings are difficult to quantify or compare.

Geo-demographic Analysis

Geo-demographics: The classification of people and places based on the combination of geographical location with demographic and socioeconomic characteristics. Geo-demographic systems (such as **ACORN** — A Classification of Residential Neighbourhoods — or **Mosaic**) group residential postcodes into categories based on census data, consumer behaviour, and other datasets.

ACORN, produced by CACI, classifies all UK postcodes into 6 categories, 18 groups, and 62 types. Categories range from "Affluent Achievers" (high-income homeowners in prosperous areas) through "Rising Prosperity" (young professionals in urban areas), "Comfortable Communities," "Financially Stretched," "Urban Adversity" to "Not Private Households." Geo-demographic classification is used by local authorities for service planning, by retailers for store siting decisions, and by geographers to analyse spatial patterns of inequality. It can also be used to understand how the character and composition of places change over time (e.g. tracking gentrification through the shifting proportion of ACORN categories in a postcode over multiple census years).

Census data applications for place study:

- Change in ethnic composition between 2001, 2011, and 2021 censuses reveals pace and pattern of demographic change.
- Housing tenure data (owner-occupied, private rented, social rented) reveals economic character and gentrification pressure.
- Occupation and qualifications data identifies socioeconomic change (increasing professional/managerial workers indicates gentrification; increasing unskilled manual indicates incoming low-income migrants).
- Comparing IMD domain scores (income, employment, education, health, crime, housing, environment) gives a multi-dimensional picture of deprivation or affluence.

Photographic Survey Methods

Photography is a powerful research tool for place study but requires systematic, critical application:

Method	Description	Strengths	Limitations
Systematic photographic transect	Photographs taken at regular intervals along a transect through a place, capturing consistent angles (e.g. frontages of all properties) to enable comparison.	Systematic, comparable, repeatable; reveals spatial variation; can be repeated to show change over time.	Time of day and weather affect quality; framing choices still involve subjectivity.
Photo elicitation	Participants are given cameras and asked to photograph what is meaningful to them about a place. Images are then discussed in interviews, using photographs as prompts.	Reveals what matters to insiders; empowers participants; accesses non-verbal meaning and emotion; produces unexpected insights.	Technically demanding for participants; analysis is complex; raises privacy issues (photographing people without consent).
Rephotography (repeat photography)	Existing historical photographs of a place are used to recreate images from the same viewpoint, enabling direct visual comparison of change over time.	Powerful visual evidence of change; engages with historical sources; accessible to non-specialists.	Requires locating historical photographs and identifying exact viewpoints; changes may be gradual and not visible at photographic scale.
Google Street View analysis	Street-level imagery from Google Street View is systematically analysed (e.g. recording shop types, building condition, street furniture) as a form of remote visual survey.	Safe, free, time-efficient; enables virtual fieldwork; Google's historical archive allows comparison across years (from 2008 in many UK cities).	Images may be outdated; can't capture atmosphere, smell, or sound; framing reflects Google's camera, not the researcher's eye; some areas have privacy restrictions.

Media Representations Analysis

Critical analysis of media representations is a core skill for AQA Changing Places. When analysing any representation of a place (photograph, text, film, map, advertisement, social media post), apply the following framework:

1. **Who produced it?** — Government/tourism board? Private business? Journalist? Resident? Artist?
Each has different purposes and biases.
2. **What is the purpose?** — To attract tourists? Sell property? Report news? Document heritage?
Critique inequality? Purpose shapes selection.
3. **What is included and foregrounded?** — What aspects of the place are emphasised, made central, or presented positively?
4. **What is excluded or marginalised?** — What aspects are absent, cropped out, or presented only as background? Who is not shown?
5. **Who is the intended audience?** — How does this shape the selection and framing?
6. **What narrative or story is constructed?** — What "version" of the place does this create? Is it decline? Regeneration? Heritage? Diversity? Threat?
7. **Whose perspective is privileged?** — Is it an insider or outsider view? Which social groups are represented, and how?
8. **What are the real-world effects of this representation?** — Does it attract investment or tourists? Does it stigmatise? Does it influence planning decisions? Does it reinforce or challenge inequalities?

Media Representations of Sheffield: From Steel City to "Cool Sheffield"

Sheffield's representation has shifted dramatically over four decades. **1980s:** Sheffield was represented in national media as a symbol of industrial decline and deprivation following the collapse of the steel industry — 100,000 manufacturing jobs lost between 1979 and 1984. The film *The Full Monty* (1997), set in Sheffield, captured this narrative of unemployment, masculinity in crisis, and community resilience in a post-industrial city. **2000s onwards:** Sheffield's self-representation shifted towards cultural amenities, two major universities (University of Sheffield and Sheffield Hallam), the Meadowhall shopping centre (ironically sited on a former steelworks), the Devonshire Quarter's independent music and café scene, and green spaces (Sheffield has more trees per person than any other UK city outside London). VisitSheffield's marketing foregrounds these qualities while the steel and deindustrialisation narrative is increasingly consigned to heritage museums (Kelham Island Museum). **Arctic Monkeys effect:** The

emergence of the Arctic Monkeys (from High Green, Sheffield) in the mid-2000s created a global "cool Sheffield" narrative associated with authentic indie music culture — a form of cultural place branding that no marketer could manufacture. These shifts illustrate how place representations are dynamic, contested, and profoundly connected to economic transformation.

Exam Tip: AQA's Changing Places specification requires you to have studied **two contrasting places** in depth: (1) a **local place** (your home area, studied through fieldwork and local knowledge) and (2) a **contrasting distant place** (studied through secondary sources). Ensure you have specific data for both: IMD scores, census statistics, named developments, house prices, and employment figures. Named theorists (Tuan, Relph, Massey, Harvey) should be woven into your analysis, not merely listed.

Exam Tip: The 20-mark essay on Changing Places will likely ask you to "evaluate the extent to which..." or "assess the importance of..." a specific factor (e.g. globalisation, government policy, or media representation) in shaping place identity. Structure your essay with: (1) a clear thesis statement answering the question directly, (2) 3–4 paragraphs of developed argument using named examples and theorists, (3) counterarguments and limitations, and (4) a nuanced conclusion that weighs the evidence. Avoid narrative description — every paragraph must advance an argument.